

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

General IT English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For IT operations, service desk, infrastructure, cloud, endpoint, security, and platform teams.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 IT Service Language, Tickets, and Triage

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Networks, Connectivity, and Root-Cause Hypotheses

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

03 Identity, Access, and Permissions

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

04 Cloud, Infrastructure, and Cost-Aware Operations

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

05 Endpoints, Servers, Patching, and Configuration Management

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

06 Security Operations, Risk, and Incident Response

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

07 Change, Release, Problem, and Post-Incident Communication

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

08 Platform, DevOps, Observability, and Kubernetes Conversations

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

IT Service Language, Tickets, and Triage

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

A ticket says "the system is down." The requester can sign in but cannot export invoices. Other functions have not been checked.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Incident - An unplanned interruption or reduction in service quality that needs restoration.

Service request - A standard user request, such as access, equipment, information, or a routine change.

Problem - An underlying cause or recurring pattern behind one or more incidents.

SLA - A formal service-level agreement, often with customer or contractual consequences.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Improve this sentence: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - B. Could you confirm when the review starts?
 - C. Could you confirm when does the review start?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - B. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?
 - C. Who will present the report at the meeting?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Narrowing the invoice-export incident

The service desk clarifies the lesson's ticket: sign-in works, invoice export does not, and other functions are untested.

01 • Service desk analyst: Your ticket says the system is down. Could you describe the action that fails?

02 • Billing specialist: I can sign in, but I cannot export invoices from the application.

03 • Service desk analyst: Thank you. Have you checked any other functions, or only sign-in and export?

04 • Billing specialist: Only those two. I don't know whether anyone else has the same issue.

05 • Service desk analyst: I'll record an invoice-export incident rather than a confirmed outage of the whole system.

06 • Billing specialist: Is that different from a service request for a new export feature?

07 • Service desk analyst: Yes. You're reporting a function that isn't working, not requesting a new capability.

08 • Billing specialist: Can you tell me when it will be fixed under the SLA?

09 • Service desk analyst: I need to check the applicable service agreement and triage the impact before discussing timing.

10 • Billing specialist: Understood. I'll describe the failed action in the ticket without expanding the affected scope.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A printer queue needs an impact check

A separate fictional office: one receptionist reports a stuck label-printing job; another printer has not been tested.

01 • Service desk analyst: Which printer is affected, and what happens when you submit a label job?

02 • Reception supervisor: The reception label job stays in the queue. I haven't tested another printer.

03 • Service desk analyst: Does the ticket concern a single stuck job or every job in that queue?

04 • Reception supervisor: I only know about my job. I shouldn't have written that printing is unavailable everywhere.

05 • Service desk analyst: That's useful clarification. What work is currently blocked by this incident?

06 • Reception supervisor: I need these labels for reception work, but I haven't assessed the wider impact.

07 • Service desk analyst: I'll capture that limitation and ask the support team to check the queue.

08 • Reception supervisor: Should I raise a separate problem record because this feels familiar?

09 • Service desk analyst: Let's first check earlier tickets. A similar symptom doesn't establish a shared underlying problem.

10 • Reception supervisor: I'll provide the job reference and avoid creating duplicate tickets while you review it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A request for equipment is not a repair

A separate fictional onboarding case: a hiring coordinator requests a second monitor for a new starter; no existing device has failed.

01 • Hiring coordinator: I marked this urgent incident because the new starter needs a second monitor.

02 • Service desk analyst: Has any assigned equipment failed, or are you requesting additional equipment?

03 • Hiring coordinator: Nothing has failed. This is an additional monitor, and approval hasn't been checked.

04 • Service desk analyst: Then let's describe it as a service request and identify the approval route.

05 • Hiring coordinator: Will changing the category guarantee that the equipment arrives before the start date?

06 • Service desk analyst: No. Categorization clarifies the work; stock, approval, and fulfillment timing still need checking.

07 • Hiring coordinator: What information should I supply so the request can be assessed properly?

08 • Service desk analyst: Please provide the role's requirement and intended start date, without assuming the request is approved.

09 • Hiring coordinator: I'll add those details and ask who can authorize the equipment.

10 • Service desk analyst: I'll confirm the next step and applicable service expectations once the request is reviewed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | IT Service Language, Tickets, and Triage

A ticket says "the system is down." The requester can sign in but cannot export invoices. Other functions have not been checked.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Which action fails, and what message do you see? I understand that sign-in works but invoice export does not. When did the problem start, and who else is affected?

Scenario 2 | A missing shared-folder shortcut

In a fictional office, an employee's shared-folder shortcut no longer opens. The folder's web link still works. Only one device has been checked, and no files are known to be missing.

Role A: You are the service desk analyst. Clarify the failed action and affected scope.

Role B: You are the records coordinator. Explain the two observed outcomes and ask how the incident will be described.

Possible opening: The shortcut fails, but the web link opens; let's separate those two observations.

Success checks

- State both observed outcomes.
- Avoid claiming data loss or an organization-wide outage.
- Agree a precise ticket description and the next diagnostic question.

Add a complication: A manager wants the ticket labeled data loss even though no missing file has been identified.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Networks, Connectivity, and Root-Cause Hypotheses

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

Staff can reach an internal application on the office network but not through the VPN. Someone announces that DNS is the cause without testing it.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

DNS - The system that resolves names such as app.example.com to network addresses.

VPN - A protected tunnel that allows remote users or sites to access private resources.

Gateway - The route a device uses to reach networks outside its local segment.

Firewall - A control that allows, blocks, or inspects network traffic based on rules.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Improve this sentence: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - B. The change must have caused the delay.
 - C. The change definitely caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - B. Across the service, the observed result was ...
 - C. In this pilot, the observed result was ...

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The VPN difference is not a DNS diagnosis

Engineers examine the lesson's internal application, reachable in the office but not through the VPN.

01 • Service desk lead: People can reach the application in the office, but not through the VPN.

02 • Network engineer: That comparison is useful. It doesn't yet establish whether DNS is responsible.

03 • Service desk lead: A colleague already announced a DNS fault. Should I repeat that in the update?

04 • Network engineer: No. Say the failure is observed on the VPN path and the cause is unconfirmed.

05 • Service desk lead: Could a gateway or firewall issue also fit the symptom we have?

06 • Network engineer: Those are possible hypotheses, not findings. We need evidence from the affected connection.

07 • Service desk lead: What comparison would help without changing several settings at the same time?

08 • Network engineer: Check name resolution and connection results for the same application from both paths.

09 • Service desk lead: I'll preserve the observed difference and remove the unsupported diagnosis from my summary.

10 • Network engineer: I'll investigate the hypotheses and report which tests support or weaken each one.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

One hostname works, another does not

A separate fictional network test: a laptop reaches the intranet hostname but not a reporting hostname; no DNS response has been inspected.

01 • Network technician: The intranet opens, but the reporting hostname doesn't. I suspect a name-resolution issue.

02 • Application engineer: That's possible, but have we inspected the DNS response for the reporting name?

03 • Network technician: Not yet. I only have the browser result from this laptop.

04 • Application engineer: Then don't describe a DNS failure as confirmed. The browser result covers several possible stages.

05 • Network technician: Would a successful intranet visit rule out the gateway as a cause?

06 • Application engineer: It shows one path worked, not that every destination uses an identical path.

07 • Network technician: I'll collect the reporting lookup result and the time of the failed attempt.

08 • Application engineer: Good. Keep the application name and test device consistent so the evidence is comparable.

09 • Network technician: We can then decide whether to investigate resolution, routing, or the application response.

10 • Application engineer: Exactly. The update should distinguish our observation from the explanation we're still testing.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A firewall change and an uncertain cause

A separate fictional incident: connection errors appeared after a firewall change, but no rule-level evidence has been reviewed.

01 • Incident coordinator: Connection errors began after the firewall change. Can we say the change caused them?

02 • Network engineer: We can report the timing, but we haven't linked the errors to a particular rule.

03 • Incident coordinator: The sequence looks convincing. What evidence would make the causal statement stronger?

04 • Network engineer: We need affected connection details and relevant firewall logs, compared with the approved change.

05 • Incident coordinator: Should I ask users to bypass the firewall while we investigate?

06 • Network engineer: No. We should use the authorized incident process, not invent an unreviewed workaround.

07 • Incident coordinator: Then I'll say the change is a hypothesis under investigation, not the established root cause.

08 • Network engineer: Please include the observed error period and avoid claiming every connection is affected.

09 • Incident coordinator: I'll request the evidence through the incident channel and keep the scope bounded.

10 • Network engineer: I'll review it and explain what we can actually conclude before recommending any change.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Networks, Connectivity, and Root-Cause Hypotheses

Staff can reach an internal application on the office network but not through the VPN. Someone announces that DNS is the cause without testing it.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The problem appears when users connect through the VPN. DNS is one possible cause, but we have not confirmed it. Let's record the tests and distinguish findings from hypotheses.

Scenario 2 | The wired-versus-wireless comparison

In a fictional office, one laptop reaches a file portal over a wired connection but not over wireless. Both tests used the same account. No other device or network log has been checked.

Role A: You are the network analyst. Separate the confirmed comparison from possible causes.

Role B: You are the support lead. Challenge the claim that the wireless access point is definitely faulty.

Possible opening: The same laptop and account work over wired access, but that does not yet identify the wireless failure's cause.

Success checks

- Preserve the single-device scope.
- Describe an equipment fault as a hypothesis only.
- Agree another bounded check before recommending replacement.

Add a complication: Someone proposes replacing equipment immediately because the two results look decisive.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Identity, Access, and Permissions

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

SITUATION

A temporary analyst requests administrator access to download a monthly report.
A reporting role may provide the necessary access.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

IAM - Identity and access management: systems and policies controlling who can access what.

Authentication - Verifying who a user, service, or device is.

Authorization - Determining what the verified identity is allowed to do.

Least privilege - Giving only the access required for the job, for only as long as needed.

3. Notice the language

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Improve this sentence: Please revert soonest with the necessary.

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask for an actionable next step

4. Check the language

1. What does 'Please send it by Thursday' normally mean?
 - A. Send it on Thursday, but not earlier.
 - B. Keep sending it regularly until Thursday.
 - C. Send it no later than Thursday.
2. Which request gives the recipient enough detail to act?
 - A. Could you confirm that you received my earlier message?
 - B. Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?
 - C. Could you confirm that the review is important?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Requesting the reporting role

The lesson's temporary analyst needs a monthly download and has requested administrator access; a reporting role may suffice.

01 • Temporary analyst: Could you give me administrator access so I can download the monthly report?

02 • Access administrator: Please request the specific reporting function instead. We need to check the narrower role first.

03 • Temporary analyst: I can authenticate successfully, so why can't I already download the file?

04 • Access administrator: Authentication verifies your sign-in; authorization determines which actions your account may perform.

05 • Temporary analyst: Then could you assess whether the reporting role authorizes the download I need?

06 • Access administrator: Yes. Please include the report name, business purpose, and required access period in the request.

07 • Temporary analyst: I don't have approval yet. Should I describe the role as already agreed?

08 • Access administrator: No. The request should go to the relevant owner for approval under our access process.

09 • Temporary analyst: I'll submit the bounded request and explain why administrator rights may be unnecessary.

10 • Access administrator: I'll review the least-privilege option without promising access before authorization is confirmed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Read access for a contractor review

A separate fictional project: a contractor must review one test dashboard for a week; editing is not part of the requested work.

01 • Project manager: Could we arrange dashboard access for the contractor's one-week review of our test results?

02 • IAM specialist: Which dashboard is needed, and does the contractor need to edit anything?

03 • Project manager: Only the test dashboard. The assignment is review, so editing isn't part of the request.

04 • IAM specialist: Then let's assess a read-only role rather than a broader workspace permission.

05 • Project manager: Can you copy another engineer's access to make the setup quicker?

06 • IAM specialist: That could include unrelated authorization. Least privilege means matching access to this specific work.

07 • Project manager: I'll identify the dashboard owner and ask them to review the read-only request.

08 • IAM specialist: Please include the one-week duration so removal or expiry can be addressed explicitly.

09 • Project manager: I'll also state that the start depends on approval, not assume today's access is guaranteed.

10 • IAM specialist: Good. I'll check the available role and return any missing information before provisioning.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Ending access after a temporary assignment

A separate fictional service team: an analyst's temporary reporting assignment has ended, but the corresponding role remains listed on the account.

01 • Service owner: The temporary assignment ended, but the reporting role is still listed on the analyst's account.

02 • Access administrator: Are you requesting removal of that role only, or closure of the entire account?

03 • Service owner: The role only. I don't have information about the analyst's other work.

04 • Access administrator: That's an important limit. Please identify the assignment and the role in your request.

05 • Service owner: Could you remove it before the next access review, once the owner approves?

06 • Access administrator: I'll check the authorization route and confirm timing rather than promise an unapproved change.

07 • Service owner: Would disabling authentication be a simpler way to enforce least privilege?

08 • Access administrator: It would affect all account use. Your request concerns one authorization, not every sign-in.

09 • Service owner: Understood. I'll keep the requested action narrow and ask the owner to confirm removal.

10 • Access administrator: I'll report the role's status after the approved action, including any work still pending.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Identity, Access, and Permissions

A temporary analyst requests administrator access to download a monthly report. A reporting role may provide the necessary access.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: Could you confirm the report and actions you need? The reporting role may be sufficient. Please include the requested end date so the access owner can review the request.

Scenario 2 | A service account with too broad a request

A fictional overnight job needs to read one inventory table. Its request asks for database-owner rights. The data owner has not reviewed the request, and no write operation is required by the supplied job description.

Role A: You maintain the job. Request assessment of read access for the named table.

Role B: You administer access. Ask for purpose and approval, and explain why the broader permission is not assumed necessary.

Possible opening: The job description requires reading one table, so could we assess that narrower permission first?

Success checks

- Tie the request to the stated read operation.
- Keep data-owner approval pending.
- Reject speculative future needs as evidence for current broad access.

Add a complication: The project lead says broad access would avoid future requests, although future needs are undefined.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Cloud, Infrastructure, and Cost-Aware Operations

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

SITUATION

Two cloud options cost \$800 and \$1,050 per month in a planning estimate. Only the second estimate includes backup storage.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

VM - Virtual machine: a software-defined server running on shared physical infrastructure.

Container - A packaged application unit with dependencies and runtime isolation.

Region - A cloud provider geographic area containing multiple data-center locations.

Tagging - Applying metadata labels to resources for ownership, cost, automation, or policy.

3. Notice the language

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Improve this sentence: This option is more better.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Explain a fair comparison

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence expresses a clear contrast?
 - A. Option A is faster, so option B costs less.
 - B. Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.
 - C. Option A is faster because option B costs less.
2. A rate increases from 6% to 7%. What is the absolute difference?
 - A. An increase of one percentage point.
 - B. An increase of one percent relative to the original rate.
 - C. An increase of seven percentage points.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Comparing cloud estimates with the same backup scope

The lesson's cloud estimates are \$800 and \$1,050 monthly; only the second includes backup storage.

01 • Procurement analyst: The first cloud option is \$800 monthly, so it looks \$250 cheaper than the second.

02 • Cloud engineer: The second estimate includes backup storage. The first leaves that cost out.

03 • Procurement analyst: Then the price difference doesn't yet compare the same service scope?

04 • Cloud engineer: Correct. We need a comparable backup allowance before calling either option less expensive overall.

05 • Procurement analyst: Should I also check whether the VM size and region assumptions match?

06 • Cloud engineer: Yes. Those details affect the comparison, and we haven't established that they are identical.

07 • Procurement analyst: Could tagging tell us which team should own each cost after deployment?

08 • Cloud engineer: It could support cost allocation if we define and apply the tags consistently.

09 • Procurement analyst: I'll request an aligned estimate instead of recommending the apparently cheaper figure today.

10 • Cloud engineer: Then we can explain the real tradeoffs without hiding the missing backup component.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

An idle test VM still appears on the estimate

A separate fictional test environment compares a continuously available VM with a proposed scheduled VM; restart time has not been measured.

01 • Product owner: The scheduled VM option looks attractive because we don't run tests overnight.

02 • Infrastructure engineer: It may reduce running time, but we need to compare availability and restart effort too.

03 • Product owner: Does stopping the VM mean every associated cloud cost stops as well?

04 • Infrastructure engineer: We shouldn't assume that. The estimate must identify storage and other retained resources separately.

05 • Product owner: The continuously available option avoids waiting for a restart, whereas the scheduled one may not.

06 • Infrastructure engineer: Exactly. We haven't measured that restart time or checked the test team's access pattern.

07 • Product owner: Let's ask about early test runs before accepting a narrower availability window.

08 • Infrastructure engineer: I'll also check resource tagging so the comparison includes the same environment in both cases.

09 • Product owner: Then we'll compare monthly cost, availability, and the unmeasured restart impact side by side.

10 • Infrastructure engineer: Good. We have a candidate saving, not a verified recommendation to switch.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Container packaging is not a complete operating cost

A separate fictional service review compares a container deployment proposal with an existing VM estimate; monitoring is included only in the VM estimate.

01 • Platform engineer: The container proposal lists compute costs, while the VM estimate also includes monitoring.

02 • Finance partner: Can we remove monitoring from the VM estimate to make the container proposal look competitive?

03 • Platform engineer: We should compare the required operating scope, not remove necessary items to favor one option.

04 • Finance partner: So both proposals need the same monitoring assumption before we discuss total cost?

05 • Platform engineer: Yes. Container packaging doesn't by itself establish a cheaper or simpler operating model.

06 • Finance partner: What other tradeoff should the decision group hear besides the monthly estimate?

07 • Platform engineer: We should assess the team's support responsibilities and deployment requirements for each option.

08 • Finance partner: Those haven't been costed yet, so I'll identify them as open items.

09 • Platform engineer: I'll ask the service owner to confirm the required scope and region assumptions.

10 • Finance partner: Then our comparison can separate priced components from operational questions that remain unresolved.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Cloud, Infrastructure, and Cost-Aware Operations

Two cloud options cost \$800 and \$1,050 per month in a planning estimate. Only the second estimate includes backup storage.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Second round: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for scenario 1: The estimates do not yet cover the same items. The \$1,050 option includes backup storage; the \$800 option does not. Let's compare equivalent configurations before recommending one.

Scenario 2 | Two storage estimates use different retention

In a fictional planning exercise, storage option A assumes thirty days of backups and option B assumes ninety. Both use the same estimated daily data volume. The required retention period is not yet agreed.

Role A: You are the cloud analyst. Explain why the totals cannot yet establish the cheaper equivalent option.

Role B: You are the service owner. Discuss how to obtain the retention requirement before selecting an estimate.

Possible opening: The daily data assumption matches, but the backup retention periods do not.

Success checks

- Name the thirty-day and ninety-day difference.
- Keep required retention unresolved.
- Agree a like-for-like comparison after the requirement is confirmed.

Add a complication: A stakeholder proposes labeling the lower estimate best value before agreeing retention.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Endpoints, Servers, Patching, and Configuration Management

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

SITUATION

A patch reached 180 of 200 managed laptops. Twelve were offline; eight reported installation errors. A manager asks if deployment is complete.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Patch - A software update that fixes a bug, vulnerability, or compatibility issue.

MDM - Mobile device management for enforcing policies on laptops, phones, and tablets.

Asset inventory - A current list of hardware, software, owners, versions, and risk-relevant details.

Maintenance window - An approved time period for work that may affect users or services.

3. Notice the language

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Improve this sentence: Everything is progressing well.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Give a useful status update

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence says a review is finished?
 - A. The team has completed the review.
 - B. The team is completing the review.
 - C. The team plans to complete the review.
2. Which update distinguishes a plan from a confirmed fact?
 - A. Delivery is confirmed for Friday because we planned it.
 - B. The delivery plan proves that arrival will be Friday.
 - C. Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

One hundred eighty is not the whole fleet

The lesson's patch deployment reached 180 of 200 laptops; twelve were offline and eight reported installation errors.

01 • IT manager: Can I tell the department that the laptop patch deployment is complete?

02 • Endpoint administrator: Not yet. It reached 180 of 200 managed laptops; twenty still need attention.

03 • IT manager: Are all twenty failures, or do we need different follow-up actions?

04 • Endpoint administrator: Twelve were offline, while eight reported installation errors. Those are different pending categories.

05 • IT manager: Does the MDM report confirm that every successful installation has been functionally tested?

06 • Endpoint administrator: It reports deployment status. We shouldn't extend that into an unverified claim about every function.

07 • IT manager: Please separate the asset inventory count from the installation and verification status.

08 • Endpoint administrator: I will. I'll review the error group and arrange follow-up for the offline laptops.

09 • IT manager: Can you promise all twenty will be finished in the next maintenance window?

10 • Endpoint administrator: I can plan follow-up, but availability and error resolution must be checked before committing.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A server patch installed but restart pending

A separate fictional server maintenance record shows the update installed; the planned restart and application check remain pending.

01 • Service owner: The patch shows installed. May I announce that maintenance is finished for the application?

02 • Server administrator: The installation is complete, but the restart and application check are still pending.

03 • Service owner: Then installed and ready for normal service are different states in this record?

04 • Server administrator: Yes. We need to communicate the remaining steps within the agreed maintenance window.

05 • Service owner: Has anyone confirmed that the application will pass its check after the restart?

06 • Server administrator: No. That check hasn't happened, so a successful result cannot be reported yet.

07 • Service owner: The update is installed; the restart and application check are still pending.

08 • Server administrator: Please don't imply a new outage or a failed check either; neither is recorded.

09 • Service owner: Understood. Who will supply the next status once the planned steps are complete?

10 • Server administrator: I'll provide the restart result and the application owner's check, with any unresolved issue separated.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A device missing from the managed inventory

A separate fictional inventory review finds a listed laptop absent from the MDM report; its current location and management status are unknown.

01 • Asset coordinator: This laptop appears in the asset inventory but not in the current MDM report.

02 • Endpoint administrator: Then we can't include it among devices with confirmed patch status from that report.

03 • Asset coordinator: Could we mark it retired so the deployment percentage looks complete?

04 • Endpoint administrator: No. Its status is unknown. A missing management record doesn't establish retirement.

05 • Asset coordinator: What work is complete in this review, and what remains for follow-up?

06 • Endpoint administrator: We've identified the discrepancy. We still need to confirm ownership, location, and management status.

07 • Asset coordinator: I'll ask the recorded owner about the device through our normal asset process.

08 • Endpoint administrator: I'll check whether the management record uses another identifier without changing the inventory prematurely.

09 • Asset coordinator: Our update should show one unresolved inventory item, not an assumed patch success.

10 • Endpoint administrator: Exactly. We'll reconcile the records before revising the managed-device count or completion claim.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Endpoints, Servers, Patching, and Configuration Management

A patch reached 180 of 200 managed laptops. Twelve were offline; eight reported installation errors. A manager asks if deployment is complete.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Second round: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for scenario 1: The patch is installed on 180 laptops. Twelve were offline and eight returned errors. Deployment is not complete; I'll separate those groups in the follow-up report.

Scenario 2 | The kiosk configuration is only partly applied

A fictional deployment targeted ten kiosks. Seven report the new configuration, two were offline, and one has not returned a status. No functional checks have been completed.

Role A: You manage endpoints. Give a precise progress report and distinguish missing status from failure.

Role B: You own the kiosk service. Ask what remains before calling the rollout complete.

Possible opening: Seven kiosks report the configuration, but three statuses and the functional checks still need attention.

Success checks

- Account for all ten kiosks.
- Do not equate silence with success.
- Separate configuration status from functional verification and agree follow-up.

Add a complication: A sponsor asks you to count the silent kiosk as successful because it returned no error.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Security Operations, Risk, and Incident Response

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

SITUATION

An analyst notices an unusual sign-in alert and sends it to the response team. The account owner has not yet confirmed the activity.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

SIEM - Security information and event management: collects and analyzes security-relevant events.

Alert - A notification triggered when a condition may require human attention.

Vulnerability - A weakness that could be accidentally triggered or intentionally exploited.

Audit log - A record of relevant system, user, or administrative actions.

3. Notice the language

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Improve this sentence: Someone should follow up on this.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Transfer information and responsibility

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence checks that responsibility has been accepted?
 - A. I mentioned the check in my earlier email.
 - B. The check appears somewhere in the notes.
 - C. Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.
2. Which response best checks a critical handoff detail?
 - A. I saw the message, so no clarification is needed.
 - B. So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?
 - C. I assume all results are final, so we can finish.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Handing over an unconfirmed sign-in alert

The lesson's analyst hands an unusual sign-in alert to the response team; the account owner has not confirmed the activity.

01 • Security analyst: I'm handing over an unusual sign-in alert. The account owner hasn't confirmed whether the activity was theirs.

02 • Incident responder: Is compromise confirmed, or are we reviewing an alert that still needs validation?

03 • Security analyst: Only the alert is confirmed. I haven't established unauthorized access from it.

04 • Incident responder: Please identify the alert reference and where the relevant audit log can be reviewed.

05 • Security analyst: I'll attach those references in the restricted incident record, not copy sensitive details into general chat.

06 • Incident responder: What action are you asking the response team to take next?

07 • Security analyst: Review the sign-in evidence and coordinate the owner check through the response process.

08 • Incident responder: I'll take that review. Has any containment action already been reported in this handoff?

09 • Security analyst: No containment is stated here. Please verify the record before assuming any action occurred.

10 • Incident responder: Understood: unconfirmed activity, evidence references in the incident record, and validation assigned to me.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A vulnerability result without an exploit finding

A separate fictional security review: a scanner flags one test server; no exploitation evidence has been examined.

01 • Vulnerability analyst: The scanner flagged one test server. I'm handing the finding to you for validation.

02 • Server owner: Does the finding mean someone has already exploited the server's vulnerability?

03 • Vulnerability analyst: No. The scan result is not evidence that exploitation occurred, and that question hasn't been examined.

04 • Server owner: What information will help me confirm whether the finding applies to this asset?

05 • Vulnerability analyst: The scanner reference, asset identifier, and reported software detail are in the restricted review record.

06 • Server owner: I'll verify the asset configuration. Should I also promise a patch date now?

07 • Vulnerability analyst: Please assess the finding and maintenance requirements first. We haven't established a feasible date.

08 • Server owner: Then my immediate task is validation, with remediation planning dependent on the result.

09 • Vulnerability analyst: Correct. Return the evidence and any unresolved questions so the risk owner can review them.

10 • Server owner: I accept that handoff and won't describe the scan as a confirmed compromise.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A SIEM alert with an incomplete time range

A separate fictional monitoring handoff: an analyst has saved an alert and ten minutes of audit logs; earlier activity has not been reviewed.

01 • Monitoring analyst: I've saved the SIEM alert and ten minutes of related audit logs for your review.

02 • Response lead: Does that cover the full event, or only the window you examined so far?

03 • Monitoring analyst: Only that window. I haven't reviewed earlier activity, so the beginning is unknown.

04 • Response lead: Thank you. We shouldn't call the available extract a complete incident timeline.

05 • Monitoring analyst: I'll mark the coverage limits and link the original alert in the restricted record.

06 • Response lead: What remains for the next analyst besides checking the entries already collected?

07 • Monitoring analyst: They need to assess whether a wider time range is relevant and gather it appropriately.

08 • Response lead: I'll assign that assessment and preserve the existing extract as part of the evidence.

09 • Monitoring analyst: Could you repeat the open point so I know the handoff is clear?

10 • Response lead: The alert and ten-minute extract are available; event scope and earlier activity remain unestablished.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Security Operations, Risk, and Incident Response

An analyst notices an unusual sign-in alert and sends it to the response team. The account owner has not yet confirmed the activity.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Second round: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Model for scenario 1: I'm handing over an unusual sign-in alert. The timestamp and alert details are attached; the account owner's confirmation is pending. Please acknowledge receipt and confirm who will coordinate the investigation.

Scenario 2 | An attachment report before analysis

In a fictional company, an employee reported an unexpected attachment. The message reference is preserved in a restricted ticket. The attachment has not been analyzed, and the employee's interaction with it is unknown.

Role A: You are the service desk analyst. Hand over the report without labeling the attachment malicious.

Role B: You are the security responder. Confirm the evidence location and the two unresolved questions.

Possible opening: We have an unexpected-attachment report, but no analysis result or confirmed interaction history yet.

Success checks

- Keep maliciousness and user interaction unconfirmed.
- Use the restricted evidence reference instead of distributing the attachment.
- Confirm who will handle analysis and the interaction check.

Add a complication: Someone asks you to circulate the attachment broadly so colleagues can inspect it themselves.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Change, Release, Problem, and Post-Incident Communication

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

SITUATION

A change notice gave the wrong maintenance date. It said Tuesday, but the approved window is Thursday. Users have already received it.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Change - A planned modification to a service, system, configuration, process, or environment.

Rollback - A planned return to the previous working state after a failed change.

Runbook - A documented procedure for responding to known operational situations.

Problem - An underlying cause or recurring pattern behind one or more incidents.

3. Notice the language

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Improve this sentence: I'm sorry if you failed to understand.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Repair a misunderstanding

4. Check the language

1. Which apology takes responsibility for unclear wording?
 - A. I'm sorry we could not meet the original date.
 - B. I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.
 - C. I'm sorry the process took longer than expected.
2. What should follow an apology for an incorrect date?
 - A. The corrected date and the current confirmation status.
 - B. A longer explanation that never states the correct date.
 - C. A new guaranteed date even if it is unverified.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Correcting Tuesday to Thursday

The lesson's change notice incorrectly announced Tuesday; the approved maintenance window is Thursday and users already received the notice.

01 • Change coordinator: I sent the wrong maintenance date. The notice said Tuesday, but the approved window is Thursday.

02 • Service owner: Users already received it. Please make the correction clear rather than silently replacing the notice.

03 • Change coordinator: I'll acknowledge the error and identify Thursday as the approved maintenance day.

04 • Service owner: Will you also change the technical runbook to match the mistaken Tuesday announcement?

05 • Change coordinator: No. The communication was wrong; it doesn't authorize changing the approved schedule.

06 • Service owner: Good. We should not create a second change while trying to repair the first message.

07 • Change coordinator: I'll use the original distribution route and label the new notice as a correction.

08 • Service owner: Please avoid inventing a new start time if the correction only concerns the day.

09 • Change coordinator: Agreed. I'll preserve the approved details and make the date correction explicit.

10 • Service owner: Once sent, confirm distribution so the support team can answer questions consistently.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Rollback available is not rollback completed

A separate fictional release: an update said rollback was complete, but the runbook only described an available rollback option; no execution is recorded.

01 • Release manager: My status update said rollback was complete. The record actually shows only that a rollback option exists.

02 • On-call engineer: Then users may believe we restored the previous version when no execution is recorded.

03 • Release manager: I'll correct that directly: rollback is available, not confirmed as performed.

04 • On-call engineer: Can you also avoid stating that the service is restored on that basis?

05 • Release manager: Yes. Recovery status needs its own evidence; the runbook isn't proof of an outcome.

06 • On-call engineer: What should the next update say about the release decision?

07 • Release manager: That the current status is being verified and any rollback decision will follow the authorized process.

08 • On-call engineer: I'll check the execution record and service evidence without assuming the earlier message was accurate.

09 • Release manager: I'll acknowledge my incorrect wording through the same incident channel.

10 • On-call engineer: Then we'll issue a verified status rather than let a possible action become a reported event.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Closing the incident did not close the problem

A separate fictional service incident is resolved, but the underlying-cause investigation remains open; an update mistakenly says all work is finished.

01 • Problem manager: The update says all work is finished, but the underlying-cause investigation is still open.

02 • Service coordinator: I confused restoring service with completing the problem investigation. I'll correct that wording.

03 • Problem manager: Please retain the confirmed restoration rather than making it sound as though service failed again.

04 • Service coordinator: So the corrected message should separate the resolved incident from the open problem record?

05 • Problem manager: Exactly. Users need an accurate service status and visibility of the remaining investigation.

06 • Service coordinator: Should I name a root cause to make the update feel more complete?

07 • Problem manager: No. An unresolved cause should remain unresolved in the message, however inconvenient that sounds.

08 • Service coordinator: I'll explain that investigation continues and link the problem record for authorized readers.

09 • Problem manager: I'll supply the next verified finding when available, rather than promise a conclusion today.

10 • Service coordinator: Thanks. I'll send an explicit correction and preserve both statuses accurately.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Change, Release, Problem, and Post-Incident Communication

A change notice gave the wrong maintenance date. It said Tuesday, but the approved window is Thursday. Users have already received it.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Second round: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Model for scenario 1: Please disregard the Tuesday date in my earlier notice. The approved maintenance window is Thursday. I'm sorry for the confusion; the corrected notice below includes the exact time and time zone.

Scenario 2 | A notice names the wrong affected service

A fictional change notice names the payroll portal, but the approved change concerns the training portal only. The notice has been sent. No payroll work is in the approved scope.

Role A: You coordinate changes. Acknowledge the incorrect service name and state the correct scope.

Role B: You lead support. Ask how users will receive the correction and how the approved record will remain intact.

Possible opening: The notice incorrectly named payroll; the approved change concerns the training portal only.

Success checks

- Name the communication error clearly.
- Keep approved scope separate from the incorrect notice.
- Agree to send an explicit correction through the original distribution route.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests adding payroll maintenance now to make the original notice accurate.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Platform, DevOps, Observability, and Kubernetes Conversations

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

A service dashboard shows normal server CPU usage, but users report slow checkout. A colleague says the dashboard proves the service is healthy.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Log - A record of events or messages from an application, system, or device.

Metric - A numerical measurement tracked over time, such as latency or error rate.

Trace - A view of a request path across services and dependencies.

Error budget - The acceptable amount of unreliability implied by an SLO over a period of time.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Improve this sentence: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
 - B. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
 - C. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?
 - B. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?
 - C. How would you describe the next step in your own words?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Normal CPU does not measure checkout speed

The lesson's service shows normal server CPU while users report slow checkout.

01 • Product manager: The server CPU graph is normal. Doesn't that prove checkout is healthy?

02 • Site reliability engineer: It measures processor use, not the entire experience of completing a checkout.

03 • Product manager: Then the metric and the user reports aren't necessarily contradicting each other?

04 • Site reliability engineer: Correct. A delay elsewhere in the request path may not appear as high CPU.

05 • Product manager: Would a trace help explain that request path in plain terms?

06 • Site reliability engineer: Yes. A trace follows stages of a request; a log records particular events.

07 • Product manager: So we need checkout timing evidence, rather than another claim based on the CPU chart.

08 • Site reliability engineer: Exactly. We should inspect relevant metrics, logs, and traces before identifying a cause.

09 • Product manager: I'll stop calling the dashboard proof that users are mistaken.

10 • Site reliability engineer: I'll investigate the reported experience and distinguish confirmed timing from possible explanations.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A running pod is not a successful purchase

A separate fictional Kubernetes service: its pods are running, but no customer-journey test has been reviewed.

01 • Platform engineer: The dashboard says the pods are running. The release coordinator wants to call the service verified.

02 • Service owner: Running describes the workload's state, not whether a customer can complete a purchase.

03 • Platform engineer: Could you explain that distinction for the release meeting without platform terminology?

04 • Service owner: The software has started, but we haven't checked that the intended task works from beginning to end.

05 • Platform engineer: Then a normal infrastructure metric can't replace the customer-journey test we haven't reviewed.

06 • Service owner: Right. We need evidence at the level of the claim we're making.

07 • Platform engineer: I'll bring the workload status and mark the purchase verification as pending.

08 • Service owner: Please include any relevant trace when the test runs so we can locate a failure.

09 • Platform engineer: And if the test fails, we'll use logs for specific events rather than guess from pod status.

10 • Service owner: Exactly. Let's communicate two separate checks instead of compressing them into one green label.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An error budget is not permission to ignore users

A separate fictional reliability review: a service remains within its agreed monthly error budget, but users have reported a new failure pattern.

01 • Release lead: We still have error budget remaining. Can we ignore the new failure reports?

02 • Reliability engineer: No. The budget tracks allowed unreliability against our chosen objective; it doesn't make individual failures irrelevant.

03 • Release lead: So being within the monthly limit isn't the same as every workflow working correctly?

04 • Reliability engineer: Exactly. A monthly metric can hide a new pattern or a problem affecting a smaller group.

05 • Release lead: What evidence should we request before deciding whether another release can proceed?

06 • Reliability engineer: The affected workflow, timing, and related logs or traces, alongside the current objective measurements.

07 • Release lead: I'll ask for that review without claiming the budget itself grants release approval.

08 • Reliability engineer: Good. The decision should consider the new evidence and our agreed release process.

09 • Release lead: I'll describe the remaining budget as context, not as a dismissal of the reports.

10 • Reliability engineer: Then we can assess the actual risk without confusing a metric with a decision.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Platform, DevOps, Observability, and Kubernetes Conversations

A service dashboard shows normal server CPU usage, but users report slow checkout. A colleague says the dashboard proves the service is healthy.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: CPU usage tells us about one part of the system. It does not measure the whole checkout experience. Let's compare it with request latency and errors for the affected period.

Scenario 2 | Averages hide a slow group

In a fictional dashboard, average request time is unchanged, but five saved user traces show long waits at checkout. The sample's representativeness and the cause are unknown.

Role A: You are the observability engineer. Explain how an average differs from individual request traces.

Role B: You are the product lead. Ask what the five traces establish and what further evidence is needed.

Possible opening: The average is unchanged, but these five traces show delays that the average alone doesn't explain.

Success checks

- Distinguish an aggregate metric from request-level evidence.
- Keep the affected population and cause uncertain.
- Agree a bounded investigation without dismissing the observed delays.

Add a complication: A stakeholder wants to claim that every customer is affected based on the five traces.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | IT Service Language, Tickets, and Triage

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: B - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

B: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

C: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

Check 2: A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

B: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

C: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

Model response: Which action fails, and what message do you see? I understand that sign-in works but invoice export does not. When did the problem start, and who else is affected?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Networks, Connectivity, and Root-Cause Hypotheses

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: A - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

B: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

C: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

Check 2: C - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

B: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

C: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

Model response: The problem appears when users connect through the VPN. DNS is one possible cause, but we have not confirmed it. Let's record the tests and distinguish findings from hypotheses.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Identity, Access, and Permissions

Editing example: Could you send the missing document and confirm when it will be available?

The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Check 1: C - Send it no later than Thursday.

A: "By Thursday" permits earlier delivery; it is not restricted to that day.

B: This interprets a deadline as a continuing activity, which would use "until".

C: 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

Check 2: B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

A: This checks receipt, not which version is required for the review.

B: The requested action and information are explicit.

C: This checks importance rather than identifying the needed document version.

Model response: Could you confirm the report and actions you need? The reporting role may be sufficient. Please include the requested end date so the access owner can review the request.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Cloud, Infrastructure, and Cost-Aware Operations

Editing example: This option is better on cost, but slower to deliver.

'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Check 1: B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.

A: 'So' implies one fact causes the other.

B: 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

C: 'Because' claims a causal connection that is not given.

Check 2: A - An increase of one percentage point.

A: Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

B: A one-percent relative increase on 6% would be 6.06%, not 7%.

C: The new rate is 7%; the difference between the rates is one percentage point.

Model response: The estimates do not yet cover the same items. The \$1,050 option includes backup storage; the \$800 option does not. Let's compare equivalent configurations before recommending one.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Endpoints, Servers, Patching, and Configuration Management

Editing example: Three checks are complete; two remain open and are being reviewed.

The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Check 1: A - The team has completed the review.

A: 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.

B: 'Is completing' presents the work as in progress.

C: 'Plans to complete' describes an intention, not completion.

Check 2: C - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.

A: A plan does not establish carrier confirmation.

B: A plan cannot prove a future arrival time.

C: This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

Model response: The patch is installed on 180 laptops. Twelve were offline and eight returned errors. Deployment is not complete; I'll separate those groups in the follow-up report.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Security Operations, Risk, and Incident Response

Editing example: Please confirm which team has accepted the follow-up task.

The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Check 1: C - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.

A: Mentioning a task does not show that anyone accepted it.

B: A written record alone does not identify who will act.

C: It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.

Check 2: B - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?

A: Receiving a message is not the same as confirming its meaning.

B: This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

C: It changes pending information into a final result.

Model response: I'm handing over an unusual sign-in alert. The timestamp and alert details are attached; the account owner's confirmation is pending. Please acknowledge receipt and confirm who will coordinate the investigation.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Change, Release, Problem, and Post-Incident Communication

Editing example: I'm sorry my message did not explain the timing clearly.

The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Check 1: B - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.

A: This acknowledges a missed date, not the communication problem in the question.

B: This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.

C: This acknowledges duration, but does not take responsibility for the unclear wording.

Check 2: A - The corrected date and the current confirmation status.

A: A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

B: The reader still lacks the information they need.

C: An unsupported new promise can create a second misunderstanding.

Model response: Please disregard the Tuesday date in my earlier notice. The approved maintenance window is Thursday. I'm sorry for the confusion; the corrected notice below includes the exact time and time zone.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Platform, DevOps, Observability, and Kubernetes Conversations

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

B: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

C: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

Check 2: C - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

B: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

C: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

Model response: CPU usage tells us about one part of the system. It does not measure the whole checkout experience. Let's compare it with request latency and errors for the affected period.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: General IT English

Professional audience: IT operations, service desk, infrastructure, cloud, endpoint, security, and platform teams

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: IT Service Language, Tickets, and Triage

Original fictional case: A ticket says "the system is down." The requester can sign in but cannot export invoices. Other functions have not been checked.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: Incident: An unplanned interruption or reduction in service quality that needs restoration. / Service request: A standard user request, such as access, equipment, information, or a routine change. / Problem: An underlying cause or recurring pattern behind one or more incidents. / SLA: A formal service-level agreement, often with customer or contractual consequences.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Which action fails, and what message do you see? I understand that sign-in works but invoice export does not. When did the problem start, and who else is affected?

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Get feedback on a draft

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

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Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Which action fails, and what message do you see? I understand that sign-in works but invoice export does not. When did the problem start, and who else is affected?

END REFERENCE

TASK: Coach my workplace writing

1. Ask me to paste my own fictional or anonymized draft and identify its reader and purpose. If the reference gives a writing task, mention that task as the default. If it is a dialogue, suggest a brief follow-up message that records its outcome and open questions. Stop and wait. Do not write the message for me first.
2. Once I supply the draft, check it against the reference. If an ambiguity changes the meaning, ask one focused question before rewriting. Do not assume that the draft is correct evidence for a new deadline, approval, diagnosis, cost or commitment.
3. Give feedback in three parts: one effective phrase with a reason; up to three priority improvements, quoting my words; and one short revision task for me. Prioritize incorrect facts or unclear action before minor grammar. For each language correction, explain why it matters to this reader. Label optional stylistic alternatives separately and preserve my level of certainty and intended politeness.
4. Stop and wait for my revision. Then compare the two attempts, identify an improvement and offer one edited version that preserves my voice and purpose. Keep the requested length; if none is specified, use 70-110 words. Explain any meaningful change rather than silently making the message stronger or more certain.
5. Close with one phrase worth reusing and a short transfer task for a different fictional reader. Wait for my attempt before providing another model.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level